METRIC
A-A-20325
March 12, 2001

COMMERCIAL ITEM DESCRIPTION

FISH NUGGETS, PORTIONS, STICKS, STRIPS, BITE-SIZE PIECES, OVEN-READY, BREADED AND/OR BATTERED, FROZEN

The U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) has authorized the use of this Commercial Item Description.

1. SCOPE. This Commercial Item Description (CID) covers frozen, breaded and/or battered, oven-ready, fish nuggets, portions, sticks, strips, and bite-size pieces (fishery products), packed in commercially acceptable containers, suitable for use by Federal, State, local governments, and other interested parties.

2. PURCHASER NOTES.

2.1 Purchasers *shall specify* the following:

- Fish specie(s), style(s), form(s), type(s), oven-ready weight(s), shape(s), fried type(s), composition(s), coating(s), and child nutrition (CN) labeling required. (Sec. 3).
- When the storage requirements are different than specified (Sec. 5.2.8).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's certification (Sec. 8.2) or National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) certification (Sec. 8.3).

2.2 Purchasers *may specify* the following:

- Breading flavor(s) (Sec. 3).
- Manufacturer's quality assurance (Sec. 8.1).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial (Sec. 9).

3. CLASSIFICATION. The fishery products shall conform to the following list as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

Fish species, styles, forms, types, oven-ready weights, shapes, fried types, compositions, coatings, breading flavors, and CN labeling.

Fish species I - Alaska Pollock
Fish species II - Cod
Fish species III - Other

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Style A - Fillet block
Form a - Single frozen (frozen once before processing)
Form b - Twice frozen (frozen twice before processing)

Style B - Minced block

Type 1 - Nugget
Oven-ready weight a - 24.38 g (0.86 oz.) - 24.81 g (0.875 oz.)
Oven-ready weight b - 28.35 g (1.00 oz.)
Oven-ready weight c - 31.18 g (1.10 oz.)
Oven-ready weight d - Other

Shape (1) - Nugget
Shape (2) - Nautical shapes
Shape (3) - Other

Type 2 - Portion
Oven-ready weight a - 85.05 g (3.00 oz.)
Oven-ready weight b - 102.06 g (3.60 oz.)
Oven-ready weight c - 113.40 g (4.00 oz.)
Oven-ready weight d - Other

Shape (1) - Rectangle
Shape (2) - Wedge
Shape (3) - Other

Type 3 - Stick
Oven-ready weight a - 28.35 g (1.00 oz.)
Oven-ready weight b - 42.52 g (1.50 oz.)
Oven-ready weight c - Other

Type 4 - Strip
Oven-ready weight a - 28.35 g (1.00 oz.)
Oven-ready weight b - 35.44 g (1.25 oz.)
Oven-ready weight c - 36.85 g (1.30 oz.)
Oven-ready weight d - 42.52 g (1.50 oz.)
Oven-ready weight e - Other

Type 5 - Bite-size piece
Oven-ready weight a - 14.17 g (.50 oz.)
Oven-ready weight b - 21.26 g (.75 oz.)
Oven-ready weight c - Other

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Un-fried fish type a - Un-fried (See section 5.1.9.1 for clarification)
Composition (a) - Meets the requirements of U.S. Grade A [Portions - 75 percent by weight of fish flesh; all other fishery product types - 72 percent by weight of fish flesh]
Composition (b) - Meets the requirements of Packed Under Federal Inspection (PUFI) [All fishery product types - minimum of 50 percent by weight of fish flesh]

Fried fish type b - Fried (See section 5.1.9.2 for clarification)
Composition (a) - Meets the requirements of U.S. Grade A [Portions - 65 percent by weight of fish flesh; all other fishery product types - 60 percent by weight of fish flesh]
Composition (b) - Meets the requirements of PUFI [Breaded fishery product types - minimum of 50 percent by weight of fish flesh; battered fishery product types - minimum of 40 percent by weight of fish flesh]

Coating (1) - Crumb Coated Breading (Bread or cracker crumb) 1/
Coating (2) - Crispy style Breading 1/
Coating (3) - Cornmeal Breading
Coating (4) - Battered 2/
Coating (5) - Other

1/ Flavored breading may be selected for Coating 1 and Coating 2.
2/ Not available with Un-fried fish type a

Breading Flavor (a) - Potato flavored
Breading Flavor (b) - Honey flavored
Breading Flavor (c) - Other

CN labeling 1 - With a CN label 3/ 4/
CN labeling 2 - Without a CN label

3/ Must contain enriched or whole-grain meal and/or flour.
4/ When a CN label is specified, the oven ready, frozen, breaded and/or battered, fishery products shall comply with USDA, Food and Nutrition Service (FNS), Child Nutrition Programs, National School Lunch Program (7 CFR Part 210, Appendices A and C).

4. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S NOTES. Manufacturer's/distributor's products shall meet the requirements of the:

- Salient characteristics (Sec. 5).
- Manufacturer's/distributor's product assurance (Sec. 6).
- Regulatory requirements (Sec. 7).
- Quality assurance provisions: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 8).
- Packaging requirements other than commercial: *as specified by the purchaser* (Sec. 9).

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5. SALIENT CHARACTERISTICS.

5.1 Raw Ingredients.

5.1.1 Preparation. The frozen breaded and battered, fried/un-fried, fishery products shall be prepared from frozen fish blocks, equivalent in quality to U.S. Grade A for flavor and odor and equivalent in quality to U.S. Grade B for workmanship, made from fresh or chilled, skinless fish. The fish and fishery products shall be prepared in accordance with 21 CFR Part 123, Fish and Fishery Products and with the provisions of regulations governing Processed Fishery Products, Processed Products Thereof, and Certain Other Processed Food Products, Inspection and Certification (50 CFR, Subchapter G, Part 260).

5.1.2 Fillet block. When fillet block, Style A is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, it shall be made from a single species of fish flesh as specified in the solicitation or contract or purchase order. The fillet block shall be made from fillets or fillet pieces that are skinless. It shall not contain minced or comminuted fish flesh. The block shall not be made from restructuring (re-working) pieces of fish blocks into the shape of a fish block.

5.1.3 Minced block. When minced block, Style B, is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, it may contain fish flesh from the fish species specified in the solicitation or contract or purchase order with or without additives. The minced flesh shall consist entirely of mechanically separated fish flesh.

5.1.4 Oil. When frying is used in the cooking process, vegetable oil shall be used as the frying medium. Only corn oil, cottonseed oil, soybean oil, canola oil, or a mixture of these oils shall be used. No coconut, palm kernel, or other tropical oils shall be allowed in the cooking process. The deep fat fryer oil shall be continuously filtered.

5.1.5 Flour. The wheat flour used for the fishery products shall be enriched and conform to the U.S. Standards of Identity for Enriched Flour (21 CFR § 137.165) and shall be milled from a variety of hard and/or soft wheat.

5.1.6 Batter/Breading. Commercially prepared batter/breading must be the type used to produce fishery products that will be heated in ovens by institutional users. The batter/breading shall be a commercial flour-based product that may include spices, seasonings, and other ingredients as needed to produce the desired flavor, texture, and color. Breading on un-fried fishery products shall have vegetable oil incorporated in the breader that will allow the fishery products to be oven-ready.

5.1.7 Monosodium glutamate (MSG). No MSG shall be added to the batter/breading or any other ingredient.

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5.1.8 Additives. Minced fish blocks may be modified with food additives as necessary to stabilize the product quality in accordance with the requirements in 21 CFR Parts 110 and 171.

5.1.9. Composition.

5.1.9.1 Un-fried fish products.

Shall meet the following requirements when composition (a) is required:

The breaded un-fried fish sticks, nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet the composition of product requirements for the U.S. Grade Standard for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Sticks of 72 percent by weight of fish flesh.

The breaded un-fried fish portions shall meet the composition of product requirements for the U.S. Grade Standard for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Portions of 75 percent by weight of fish flesh.

Shall meet the following requirements when composition (b) is required:

The breaded un-fried fish sticks, portions, nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet PUFI requirements of a minimum of 50 percent by weight of fish flesh.

5.1.9.2 Fried fish products.

Shall meet the following requirements when composition (a) is required:

The breaded and battered fried fish sticks, nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet the composition of product requirements for the U.S. Grade Standard for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks of 60 percent by weight of fish flesh.

The breaded and battered fried fish portions shall meet the composition of product requirements for the U.S. Grade Standard for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Portions of 65 percent by weight of fish flesh.

Shall meet the following requirements when composition (b) is required:

The breaded fried fish sticks, portions, nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet PUFI requirements of a minimum of 50 percent by weight of fish flesh.

The battered fried fish sticks, portions, nuggets, strips, and bite-sized pieces shall meet the PUFI requirements of a minimum of 40 percent by weight of fish flesh.

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5.2 Processed product.

5.2.1 Un-fried fish products composition (a) (U.S. Grade A).

5.2.1.1 Fish portions. The frozen un-fried breaded fish portions shall meet the requirements for U.S. Grade A in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Portions (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.1.2 Fish sticks. The frozen un-fried breaded fish sticks shall meet the requirements for U.S. Grade A in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.1.3 Fish nuggets, strips, bite-size pieces. The frozen un-fried breaded fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet the requirements for U.S. Grade A for defects for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.2 Un-fried fish products composition (b) (PUFI).

5.2.2.1 Fish portions. The frozen un-fried breaded fish portions shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Portions (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.2.2 Fish sticks. The frozen un-fried breaded fish sticks shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.2.3 Fish nuggets, strips, bite-size pieces. The frozen un-fried breaded fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Raw Breaded Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 4).

5.2.3 Fried fish products composition (a) (U.S. Grade A).

5.2.3.1 Fish portions. The frozen fried breaded fish portions shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Portions (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish portions shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A for defects for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Portions with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

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5.2.3.2 **Fish sticks**. The frozen fried breaded fish sticks shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish sticks shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A for defects for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

5.2.3.3 **Fish nuggets, strips, bite-size pieces**. The frozen fried breaded fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A for defects for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall meet the requirements of U.S. Grade A for defects for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

5.2.4 **Fried fish products composition (b) (PUFI)**.

5.2.4.1 **Fish portions**. The frozen fried fish portions shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Portions (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish portions shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Portions with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

5.2.4.2 **Fish sticks**. The frozen fried breaded fish sticks shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish sticks shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

5.2.4.3 **Fish nuggets, strips, bite-size pieces**. The frozen fried fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks (NOAA Manual 25, Part 2, Chapter 4, Section 6). Battered fish nuggets, strips, and bite-size pieces shall be equivalent in quality to the lowest letter grade in accordance with U.S. Standards for Grades of Frozen Fried Fish Sticks with the exception of uniformity of size and weight and the coating defect of ridges for "rippled type" batters.

5.2.5 **Individual Freezing**. The fishery products shall be individually frozen so the individual fish products can be easily separated by hand.

5.2.6 **Size and weight**. The breaded and battered fish nuggets, portions, strips, and bite-size pieces shall be at least 3/8 inch thick. The breaded and battered fish sticks shall be rectangular

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shaped and at least 3/8 inch thick and their largest dimension shall be at least three times the next largest dimension. The breaded fish products shall be uniform in size and weight.

5.2.7 Appearance. The fish products shall have no breaks or cuts greater than one-half the width or length. The fish products shall not be mashed, physically or mechanically injured, misshaped or mutilated to the extent that its appearance is materially affected.

5.2.8 Storage requirements. The manufactured frozen fish products shall be placed in a freezer within 2 hours after packaging, and frozen to an internal temperature of -17.8EC (0EF) within 24 hours after placement in the freezer. The product shall be maintained at -17.8EC (0EF) during frozen storage. Unless otherwise specified, the maximum storage time for frozen fish products at -17.8EC (0EF) or below is 360 days.

6. MANUFACTURER'S/DISTRIBUTOR'S PRODUCT ASSURANCE. The manufacturer/ distributor shall certify that the fishery products provided shall meet the salient characteristics of this CID, conform to their own specifications, standards, and quality assurance practices, and be the same fishery products offered for sale in the commercial market. The purchaser reserves the right to require proof of conformance.

7. REGULATORY REQUIREMENTS. The delivered fishery products shall comply with all applicable Federal, State, and local mandatory requirements and regulations relating to the preparation, packaging, labeling, storage, distribution, and sale of fishery products within the commercial marketplace. Delivered fishery products shall comply with all applicable provisions of the Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act and regulations promulgated thereunder. When the fishery products are used for the School Lunch Program, the fishery products shall comply with all applicable provisions of the CN programs.

8. QUALITY ASSURANCE PROVISIONS. *Purchaser shall specify 8.2 or 8.3; (8.1 is optional when 8.2 is specified).* The United States Department of Commerce (USDC), NOAA, National Marine Fishery Service (NMFS) requires 8.1 when 8.3 is specified.

8.1 Manufacturer's quality assurance. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the product manufacturer shall be required to have their facilities inspected by, NMFS, NOAA, USDC, and be eligible for listing in the USDC publication "USDC Approved List of Fish Establishments and Products." (NMFS sanitation inspections verify that, at the time of the inspection, the manufacturer demonstrated their ability to meet rigid standards of sanitation and are capable of producing safe, wholesome fishery products).

8.2 Manufacturer's/distributor's certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, the manufacturer/distributor will certify that the finished fishery products meets or exceed the requirements of this CID.

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8.3 NOAA certification. When required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order that product quality and acceptability or both be determined, the Grading Branch, NMFS, shall be the certifying program. NMFS shall certify the quality and acceptability of the fishery products in accordance with NMFS procedures which include selecting random samples of the packaged fishery products, evaluating the samples for conformance with the salient characteristics of this CID and other contractual requirements, and documenting the findings on official NMFS program score sheets and/or certificates. In addition, when required in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, NMFS will examine the fishery products for conformance to the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers in effect on the date of the solicitation.

9. PACKAGING. Preservation, packaging, packing, labeling, and case marking shall be commercial unless otherwise specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order.

10. NOAA INSPECTION NOTES. When 8.3 is specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order, NOAA certification shall include evaluation of the quality and condition of samples of packaged fishery products, and compliance with requirements in the following areas:

- Salient characteristics (Sec 5).
- Packaging requirements (Sec. 9 or as specified in the solicitation, contract, or purchase order).

11. REFERENCE NOTES.

11.1 NOAA certification contact. For NOAA certification, contact the nearest USDC Lot Inspection Office listed below.

Gloucester Lot Inspection Office
National Marine Fisheries Service
11-15 Parker Street
Gloucester, MA 01930
Telephone 978-281-9201
Fax 978-281-9223

Fairhaven Lot Inspection Office
National Marine Fisheries Service
147-B Washington Street
Fairhaven, MA 02719
Telephone 508-993-9309
Fax 508-990-0804

Virginia Inspection Office
National Marine Fisheries Service
1026G Settler's Landing Road
Hampton, VA 23669
Telephone 757-722-0664
Fax 757-723-6074

Tampa Lot Inspection Office
National Marine Fisheries Service
c/o Americold Corporation
1601 North 50th Street
Tampa, FL 33619
Telephone 813-228-2546
Fax 813-228-2980

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National Marine Fisheries Service
5600 Rickenbacker Road, Bldg. 7A
Bell, CA 90201
Telephone 323-526-7412
Fax 323-527-7417

National Marine Fisheries Service
7600 Sand Point Way N.E.
Seattle, WA 98115-6349
Telephone 206-526-4259
Fax 206-526-4264

11.2 CN labeling contact. For CN labeling information, contact the **Head, Technical Assistance Section, Child Nutrition Division, Food and Nutrition Service, 3101 Park Center Drive, Alexandria, VA 22302, telephone (703) 305-2609 or on the Internet at: http://www.fns.usda.gov/fns/.**

11.3 Sources of documents.

11.3.1 Sources of information for governmental documents are as follows:

Applicable provisions of the Food and Nutrition Service Regulations are contained in 7 CFR Part 210. The Federal Food, Drug, and Cosmetic Act are contained in 21 CFR Parts 1 to 199. Regulations Governing Processed Fishery Products, Processed Products Thereof, and Certain Other Processed Food Products, Inspection and Certification are contained in 50 CFR Subchapter G, Part 260. These documents may be purchased from: **Superintendent of Documents, ATTN: New Orders, P.O. Box 371954, Pittsburgh, PA 15250-7954. Credit card (MasterCard or Visa) purchases may be made by calling the Superintendent of Documents on (202) 512-1803 or on the Internet at: http://www.nara.gov/fedreg.**

Copies of NOAA Manual 25 are available from: **U.S. Department of Commerce, NOAA, NMFS, P.O. Drawer 1207, Pascagoula, MS 39567-1207, telephone (228) 762-1982, Fax (228) 769-1436, via E-mail: George.Haines@NOAA.gov or on the Internet at: http://seafood.nmfs.noaa.gov/standards.htm.**

Copies of "USDC Approved List of Fish Establishments and Products" are available from: **U.S. Department of Commerce, NOAA, NMFS, Seafood Inspection Service, Seafood Inspection Division, Documentation Approval and Supply Services Section, P.O. Drawer 1207, Pascagoula, MS 39568-1207, telephone (228) 762-1892, Fax (228) 769-1436, or on the Internet at: http://seafood.nmfs.noaa.gov/publications.htm.**

Copies of this CID, the United States Standards for Condition of Food Containers, and beneficial comments, recommendations, additions, deletions, clarifications, etc. and any data which may improve this CID are available from and/or provided to: **Head, Food Quality Assurance Staff, FVP, AMS, USDA, STOP 0243, 1400 Independence Ave., SW, Washington, DC 20250-0243, telephone (202) 720-9939, Fax (202) 690-0102, via E-mail: FQAStaff@usda.gov or on the Internet at: http://www.ams.usda.gov/fv/fvqual.htm.**

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MILITARY INTERESTS:

Custodians

Army GL
Navy SA
Air Force - 35

Review Activities

Army -MD, QM
Navy - MC
DLA - SS

CIVIL AGENCY COORDINATING ACTIVITIES:

DOJ - BOP
HHS - NIH, IHS
USDA - FV
VA - OSS
DOC - NOAA

PREPARING ACTIVITY:

USDA - FV

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